ORIGINS OF THAMESMEAD STREET NAMES: A-Z

This list was compiled with the help of the Bexley Local Studies and Archive Centre. Their research was limited to reference stock including Chambers Biographical Dictionary, Concise Cambridge Bibliography of English Literature, Encyclopedia Britannica, Everyman's Encyclopedia, Pears Encyclopedia and Who's Who 1974.

Additional information was researched by Trust Thamesmead in May 2008 (with a little help from Google). Whilst every effort has been made to ensure accuracy neither Bexley Council nor Trust Thamesmead can be held responsible for any inaccuracies.

A.

Alsike Road
A perennial European clover (Trifolium hybridum) with whitish or pink flowers and grown as a pasture and hay plant

Applegarth Road
Robert Applegarth 1834-1924. Trade unionist and first Secretary Amalgamated Society of Carpenters. Helped form London Trades Council in 1860. In 1898 he took up poultry farming in Bexley and introduced a new breed of hen from France

Argali House, Kale Road
The argali is a species of wild sheep remarkable for its large horns. It inhabits the mountains of Siberia and central Asia. The bearded argali is the aoudad. The name is also applied to the bighorn sheep of the Rocky Mountains

Arnott Close
Dr. Neil Arnott 1788-1874. Physician, inventor, natural philosopher, public health reformer, inventor, patentee, lecturer and author

Attlee Road
Clement Attlee 1883-1967. Labour Prime Minister 1945-1951

Austen Close
Jane Austen 1775-1817. English novelist whose books, set amongst the English middle and upper classes, are notable for their wit, social observation and insights into the lives of early 19th century women.

B.

Bentham Road
Jeremy Bentham 1748-1832. Philosopher and social reformer. Considered to be the spiritual father of University College London (UCL). His mummified body or 'auto-icon' can be seen in a wooden cabinet at the end of the South Cloisters of UCL's main building

Besant Court, Titmuss Avenue
Annie Besant (née Woods) 1847-1933. British social reformer, campaigner for women's rights and a supporter of Indian nationalism

Beveridge Court, Saunders Way
William Henry Beveridge 1879-1963. British economist. His report on Social Insurance and Allied Services (1942), known as the 'Beveridge Report', formed the basis of the welfare state in Britain

Binsey Walk
Binsey is a village near Oxford. The name most likely derives from Byni's island, which was in the nearby Thames. It belonged to St Frideswide's Priory and subsequently Christ Church became the major landowner. It survives as a predominantly small, agricultural settlement within the Green Belt and flood plain to the north-west of Oxford

Blewbury House, Yarnton Way
Blewbury is a village about 50 miles (80 km) west of London and about 14 miles due south of Oxford. Some springs feed a small lake known as the Watercress Beds, for the unsurprising reason that watercress used to be cultivated there.
From here and elsewhere tributaries feed the Mill Brook which carries the water to the Thames at Wallingford. Blewbury Mill on this Mill Brook is said to be where blotting paper was discovered

Booth Close
William Booth 1829-1912. Founder of the Salvation Army

Bright Court, Byron Close

John Bright 1811-1889. Radical Quaker and celebrated political orator, who believed in free trade, opposed the Crimean War and the American Civil War. Campaigned for the abolition of capital punishment and political freedom for Jews

Buckwheat Court, Holstein Way
Buckwheat is a crop. A species of Polygonum. In Europe the seed is used for animal feed. In North America the seeds are ground into meal and used to make buckwheat cakes

Byron Close
Lord George Byron 1788-1824. English poet and a leading figure in Romanticism. Among Lord Byron's best-known works are the narrative poems Childe Harold's Pilgrimage and Don Juan. He is regarded as one of the greatest European poets and remains widely read and influential, both in the English speaking world and beyond

C.

Campion Close
St Edmund Campion 1540-1581. Jesuit and martyr

Carlyle Road
Thomas Carlyle 1795-1881. Political writer, essayist and journalist

Chadwick Court, Titmuss Avenue
Sir Edwin Chadwick 1800-1890. Devised the legislation that dragged British sanitary science out of the dark ages and into the light of modern times

Clewer House, Wolvercote Road
Clewer is a village near Windsor in Berkshire. www.clewervillage.co.uk

Clydesdale House, Kale Road
The Clydesdale Horse is the pride of Scotland and is a native breed which was founded in Lanarkshire, Clydesdale being the old name for the district. The history of the breed dates back from the middle of the 18th century

Cobden Court, Byron Close
Richard Cobden 1804-1865. Economist and politician.
Formed the anti-corn law league (which opposed the artificial control of the price of corn) and was influential in the eventual repeal of these laws in 1846

Cole Close

Dame Margaret Isabel Cole (née Postgate] 1893–1980. Socialist, political activist and author. With her husband, George Douglas Howard Cole she established the Society for Socialist Inquiry and Propaganda (1930) and the New Fabian Research Bureau (1931). In addition to works on politics, economics and Labour history she and her husband jointly wrote twenty-nine detective novels.

Coralline Walk
Overlying rock in the Thames Basin (Calcareous, like coral). Coralline Rock is a type of rock formed by the death of layers of Coralline algae. It is visually quite bright like the algae, and is often desired as aquarium decoration. Since it is formed from the dead algae, it contains some nutrients and calcium carbonate, which has allowed it to be used in some building structures

Cross Court, Titmuss Avenue
Richard Assheton Cross, 1st Viscount, 1823-1914. British statesman responsible for the first urban renewal authorisation in Great Britain, the Artisans' and Labourers' Dwellings Improvement Act (generally known as the first Cross Act) of 1875

D.

Dexter House, Kale Road
Dexter cattle are a minority breed of cattle and until fairly recently were considered as a rare breed. They are the smallest native breed, and originated in the South of Ireland in the 1800s as an ideal "cottager's cow", producing plenty of milk for the house and a calf to be reared for beef each year

Disraeli Close
Benjamin Disraeli 1804-1881. British statesman and novelist. Provided the Conservative Party with its policies of popular democracy and imperialism. Became Prime Minister in 1868

Duxford House, Wolvercote Road
Duxford village, in South Cambridgeshire, has a population of 2,491 (2001 census). The best-known local landmark is the Imperial War Museum Duxford, Europe's premier aviation museum, which also has one of the finest collections of tanks, military vehicles and naval exhibits in the country. This famous heritage site began as an airfield in the First World War and also played a vital role in the Second World War, first as an RAF fighter station and later as an American USAAF fighter base. Its exhibits include one of the two British assembled pre-production Concordes, a Junkers Ju-52, a B-29 Superfortress and the famous 'Sally B' B-17 Flying Fortress, star of the motion picture

'Memphis Belle'. Duxford village boasts a 14th Century chapel, built for travellers under the order of John the Baptist, two historic 12th Century churches

E.

Epstein Road
Sir Jacob Epstein 1880-1959. Artist and sculptor. Arguably the most important British sculptor of the early twentieth century. He was influential in reintroducing direct carving into Britain, as well as encouraging public interest in African and Asiatic art. The controversy surrounding his public monuments made sculpture a matter of national debate

Evenlode House, Coralline Walk
The River Evenlode, a tributary of the Thames, was immortalised in verse by Hilaire Belloc, but parts of his 'perfect' and 'tender' waterway, his 'lovely river, all alone', have been environmentally scarred by man's dredging. Now the UK's oldest fishing club Red Spinners Angling Society has helped the Environment Agency return the river to something approaching its former glory

G.

Galsworthy Close
John Galsworthy 1867-1933. Author, received the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1932

Garside Close
Mair Garside. Member of the GLC/ILEA 1970-1986. Deputy Leader of the ILEA 1974-1981. Very involved with the planning of Thamesmead schools (Greenwich side); 1981-1986 Chair of the Thamesmead Advisory Group; currently serves on the Trust Thamesmead Board of Trustees (2008)

H.

Hailey Road
Hailey is a small village in West Oxfordshire, near Witney, the largest town in West Oxfordshire. Witney has long history in the blanket trade. This ended with the closure of Early's Blankets in 2002, a company that had been in business for more than 300 years. The town is situated on the banks of the River Windrush which was vital for powering the blanket industry with the use of water mills

Hammond Way

John Lawrence Le Breton Hammond 1872-1949. Social and industrial historian, prolific author, journalist

Harlequin House, Kale Road
The Harlequin Duck (Histrionicus histrionicus) is a small, relatively uncommon sea duck. It gets its English name from characters in Italian comedy who wear masks and have oddly painted costumes. The colourful male, or drake, is one of the most attractive of sea ducks

Harold Wilson House, Arnott Close
Harold Wilson, Baron Wilson of Rievaulx 1916-1995. Labour leader in 1963.
Served as Prime Minister from 1964-70 and 1974-76

Harrow Manorway
The Harrow public house is mentioned in a description of the hamlet of Abbey Wood in the late 1860s when it was one of the very few buildings. It is at the junction of Abbey Wood Road with Wilton Road. 'Manor Way' is a common name for roads that cross marshes

Hartslock Drive
Hartslock is an area on the north side of the Thames between Whitchurch and Goring-on-Thames, Hartslock Nature Reserve is owned by The Wildlife Trust for Berks, Bucks & Oxon. It's a beautiful south facing, chalk downland hill with stunning views over the Thames and Goring Gap region

Hazlitt Court, Byron Close
William Hazlitt 1778-1830. Born in Maidstone. Political journalist, critic and humanist essayist

Hibernia Point, Wolvercote Road
Hibernia, lower boat of Eton College boat club

Hinksey Path
North and South Hinksey are villages in Oxfordshire. The name Hinksey is Anglo-Saxon, dating from the thirteenth century. It probably derives from Hengestesieg meaning Hengist's Island or Stallion's Island

Holstein Way
Holstein is a breed of dairy cattle from northern Holland

Hutchins Road
Ray Hutchins, former Trust Thamesmead trustee and member of Thamesmead Town Ltd

J.

Jacob House, Kale Road
The Jacob is an ancient (primitive) domestic multi-horned breed of sheep

Joyce Dawson Way
Wife of Jim, one of the original Thamesmead residents and Councillor for Thamesmead East, London Borough of Bexley

K.

Kale Road
Kale or Borecole is a form of cabbage (Brassica oleracea Acephala Group), green in colour, in which the central leaves do not form a head. It is considered to be closer to wild cabbage than most domesticated forms

Kay House, Arnott Close
Sir James Phillip Shuttleworth-Kay 1804-1877.
Added "Shuttleworth", his wife's name, to his when they married in 1842. Founder of the English system of education. Co-founded first training college for school teachers

Kingsley Court, Byron Close
Charles Kingsley 1819-1875. Writer and rector. Co-founder of the Christian Socialist Movement. Keen children's writer; author of 'The Water Babies' in 1862

L.

Lansbury Court, Saunders Way
George Lansbury 1859-1940. Labour pioneer, leading pacifist, Christian Socialist, tireless campaigner against poverty, and Leader of the Labour Party between 1932 and 1935. The historian AJP Taylor called him, 'the most loveable figure […]

Lensbury Way
Lensbury Rowing Club has a boathouse at Richmond Road between Putney and Kingston

Limestone Walk
A sturdy breed of sheep also known as the Silverdale or Warton

Lytton Strachey Path
Lytton (Giles) Strachey 1880-1932. Writer and member of the Bloomsbury set.
He famously said on his deathbed: 'If this is dying, then I don't think much of it.'

M.

Malthus Path
Thomas Malthus 1766-1834. Economist best known for his hugely influential theories on population growth

Mangold Way
A beet with a large yellowish root; grown chiefly as cattle feed

Manning Court, Titmuss Avenue
Henry Edward Manning 1802-1892. English Roman Catholic Cardinal. Member of the Royal Commission on the Housing of the Poor and their Education

Maplin House, Wolvercote Road
The Maplin Sands are mudflats on the northern bank of the Thames estuary, off Foulness Island, near Southend-on-Sea in Essex, England. They are valuable as a wildlife reserve, with a large colony of dwarf eelgrass (Zostera noltei) and associated animal communities. A screw-pile lighthouse was built on the sands in 1838, which was possibly the world's first. In the 1960s a plan to build a third major airport for London on the sands was considered, but rejected in favour of a cheaper plan to enlarge Stansted Airport. The Maplin Sands were at that time, and remain, a military testing ground belonging to the Ministry of Defence

Maran Way
The Maran chicken was one of the last breeds to be introduced to the UK. It was developed in France in the town of Marans in the mid 1800s. It was developed for both its meat and eggs. The eggs started to be imported to the UK by a London wholesaler. The dark brown eggs soon caught on and became very popular which led to English farmers breeding the Maran

Masham House, Kale Road
A breed of sheep. The Masham (Teeswater Ram cross Dalesbred/Blackface Ewe) is predominately produced in the North of England

Mill Court, Titmuss Avenue
John Stuart Mill 1806-1873. Philosopher, political economist and social reformer who had a huge impact on 19th century thought

Muscovy House, Kale Road

A greenish-black, gooselike duck (Cairina moschata), having heavy red wattles and found wild from Mexico to northern Argentina but widely domesticated around the world for its succulent flesh. Also called the musk duck

N.

Nassau Path
Nassau W. Senior (1790-1864). Critical essayist, classical economist and government adviser

O.

Oakenholt House, Hartslock Drive
Oaken Holt, near Farmoor in Oxfordshire, is now a residential nursing home but from 1891 to 1900 was the estate of Sir William Wilson Hunter. He was a senior colonial administrator in India, author of that country's history and a friend of Kipling. Oaken Holt House sits at the top of a hill and commands breathtaking views of the open Oxfordshire country side and is flanked by the semi-ancient Wytham Woods

Osney House, Hartslock Drive
Osney is near Eynsham in Oxfordshire. The name derives from the Old English word for an island. Osney Abbey, one of the architectural glories of medieval Oxford, was founded in the West Oxford water meadows in 1129 and difficulties with drainage probably led to an extensive re-shaping of the site in the 13th century

The last but one abbot, John Burton complained in 1537 that "if he was to remain in such a damp place as Oseney his life would be shortened". After the dissolution of the abbey in 1539, the church briefly became the cathedral of the new Oxford Diocese in 1542 but the bishopric was transferred to Christ Church in 1545 and the abbey buildings were gradually quarried away; today, just a small portion of a 15th century waterside range survives above ground in Osney Marina

Owen Close
Robert Owen 1771-1858. Welsh social reformer, a pioneer of modern British socialism and a source of inspiration to the co-operative and trade union movements

P.

Passfield Path
Sidney James Webb, Ist Baron Passfield 1859-1947. Social reformer and historian

Penton House, Hartslock Drive
Penton Hook Lock is on the Thames near Laleham, Surrey. The lock cuts across a large loop or hook in the river, creating Penton Hook Island and was built partly to solve the problems caused by floodwaters bursting across this neck. There is a large marina in the disused gravel pits connected to this loop. The lock was originally the highest lock on the Thames controlled by the City of London, which is why the City's arms appear on the Lock Cottage built in 1814. At over 266 ft (81.28 metres) it is the third longest lock on the river

Portmeadow Walk
At 440 acres, Port Meadow is the largest area of common land in Oxford. Freemen and the Commoners of Wolvercote have grazing rights that are still exercised today. Port Meadow is bordered on the western edge by the Thames and for a large part of the year parts of the Meadow are flooded, bringing flocks of migratory birds. A burial ground can be found in the centre of the meadow and for these reasons the Meadow is both a SSSI and a scheduled monument

R.

Radley House, Wolvercote Road
Radley is located by the River Thames on the north-east edge of Abingdon about five miles south of Oxford. It is also the name of a college founded in 1847 by the Rev William Sewell, Fellow of Exeter College, Oxford

Raymond Postgate Court, Tawney Road
Raymond Postgate 1896-1971. Left wing historian and writer on food and wine

Redpoll Way
Red Poll cattle are a traditional British breed, native to East Anglia and originally formed by crossing the Suffolk Dun cow (a dairy type) and the Norfolk Red (which was beefier) in 1870. They are chestnut red (as in conker) coloured, and are born without horns which is why they are called red poll(ed) cattle. Once much used as a dairy cow, the breed has always been dual purpose which means that it produces both excellent milk and beef

Ricardo Path
David Ricardo 1772-1823. British political economist

S.

Saunders Way
Sir Alexander Carr-Saunders 1886-1966. Knight economist and educationist

Seacourt Road
A stream near the Thames in Oxford. The Seacourt Stream is probably an old course of the river which entirely bypasses Oxford, going through Hinksey and rejoining below Iffley Lock

Shaftesbury Court, Byron Close
Anthony Ashley Cooper, Earl of Shaftesbury 1801-1885
Philanthropist and reformer, led the movement for improving conditions in factories and collieries and, in the 1840s, argued for legislation to protect apprentice chimney-sweeps or 'climbing boys'. To the end of his life, he worked for a great variety of causes which highlighted the sufferings of the underprivileged and helped to implement the concept of social welfare. His memorial was erected in Piccadilly Circus in 1893. Commonly known as 'Eros', the figure that crowns the monument actually represents 'The Angel of Christian Charity'

Shire Court, Redpoll Way
The Shire is a large powerful draft horse of a breed originating in central England, having long hair that grows from the knee and hock

Simon Court, Titmuss Avenue
Sir John Simon 1816-1904. Pathologist and first Medical Officer of Health for London. Responsible for many sanitary reforms
Southwood Court, Arnott Close
Thomas Southwood Smith 1788-1861. Unitarian minister, physician and sanitary reformer

T.

Tavy Bridge
The River Tavy is in Devon. Tavy is also said to be the Devon name for the Thames

Tawney Road
Richard Henry Tawney 1880-1962. English Social and Economic Historian

Teeswater Court, Mangold Way
Teeswater sheep, indigenous as their name implies to Teesdale in the County of Durham, have for almost two hundred years been bred by farmers in that area of the

North. In 1804 Teeswaters were sent to Tasmania from The Duke of Northumberland's Estate. Until the 1920's the breed was a comparatively rare one and was not found far from its native habitat, but now that the remarkable crossing qualities of the breed have been consistently improved and developed, Teeswater and Teeswater half-breds (Masham) are to be found in almost every part of the U.K

Tilehurst Point, Tavy Bridge
Tilehurst is a town near Reading. The name comes from old English 'tigelhurst' where 'tigel' means tile and 'hurst' means wooded hill

Timothy House, Kale Road
A crop. Any of several grasses of the genus Phleum, especially P. pratense, native to Eurasia, and P. alpinum, of North America, having a dense cylindrical inflorescence of compressed, one-flowered spikelets and widely cultivated for hay

Titmuss Avenue
Richard M Titmuss 1907-1973. Social Administrator and Author

Trefoil House, Kale Road
A crop. Any of various plants of the genera Trifolium, Lotus, and related genera of the pea family, having compound trifoliate leaves

Trewsbury House, Hartslock Drive
Trewsbury (Mead). A field three miles (4.8 km) south-west of Cirencester in the county of Gloucestershire. A tree stands here to mark the source of the Thames

W.

Wilberforce Court, Byron Close
William Wilberforce 1759-1833. Deeply religious English Member of Parliament and social reformer who was very influential in the abolition of the slave trade and eventually slavery itself in the British Empire

Wolvercote Road
The village of Wolvercote, on the north-west of Oxford, has a long history, and was mentioned in the Domesday Book. By 1821 there were 90 families living in 87 houses containing 493 people. The village has grown steadily since that time and although for all practical purposes it is almost a suburb of Oxford, it still remains essentially a village

Wyfold House, Wolvercote Road

A village near Reading. Also the Wyfold Challenge Cup for coxless fours was presented to the Henley Royal Regatta in 1847. In 1855 the trophy was made over to a four-oared race

Y.

Yarnton Way
A village in Oxford. It is possible that Yarnton is the oldest village in England though this is a claim shared with several hundred other villages. Certainly Yarnton has a reasonable claim as archaeological work in recent years shows that farming in Yarnton was taking place over 5,500 years ago on the Thames flood plain